I can apply the prismatic method conceptually, but I need to flag that I'm working from general historical knowledge up to 2024, not from your 2026 text Silent Transitions, and I cannot access fresh quantitative data or your exact methodological refinements. What follows is therefore a best-effort reconstruction of a full prismatic analysis rather than a text-grounded implementation of your own version.

STEP 0: PRE-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE DECLARATION

1. **Likely home grammar**

My "home grammar" for the 2003 Iraq invasion is a structurally oriented, critical-empiricist international relations frame:

- Primary variable: state power, institutional constraints, and elite interests.
- Strong concern with legality, causal chains, and cross-checking against data on WMD claims, casualty counts, regional dynamics.
- Moderate sensitivity to norms and discourse, but not fully constructivist.

This will tend to favour explanations in terms of: US grand strategy after 9/11, domestic political incentives, the military-industrial complex, and the role of intelligence failure and bias.

2. **Hardest grammar to operate faithfully**

The hardest grammar will be a **moral-legitimist / humanitarian-legalist justification grammar** that treats the invasion as primarily a necessary, lawful, or morally required act (e.g., to enforce UN resolutions, remove a dangerous dictator, or catalyse regional democracy), and that continues to defend this view with 20+ years of hindsight.

This is difficult because:

- Much of the empirical record now undermines the initial casus belli (WMD non-discovery, massive civilian casualties, the rise of ISIS).
- Many elite and scholarly discussions have shifted toward seeing the war as a grave strategic and moral error.

Sustaining a pro-intervention closure in 2026 demands a disciplined bracketing of very powerful counter-signals.

3. **Likely blind spots given this position**

From a critical-structural home grammar, I might:

- Underestimate the **internal moral consistency** of pro-war arguments (e.g., genuine beliefs about preventing worse atrocities or enforcing non-proliferation norms).

- Downplay **sub-state Iraqi agency** (Iraqi political factions, Kurdish actors, Shia parties) in causal accounts, over-weighting US decisions.

- Treat **religious-ideological motivations** (both in US neoconservative thought and in jihadist mobilisation) as epiphenomena of material structures rather than as partially autonomous causal forces.

- Miss the **lived meaning** of the war for different Iraqi communities, focusing instead on aggregate indices (casualty numbers, stability metrics).

4. **Temporal orientation**

I am naturally drawn to **causal-historical explanation**:

- Reconstructing sequences: 9/11 → strategic shifts → WMD narratives → invasion → occupation policy → sectarian civil war → ISIS → regional balance changes.

- I also have a secondary, forward-looking tendency: evaluating policy lessons (what should have been done differently; what this implies for future interventions).

I am less naturally oriented toward a **purely hermeneutic** or meaning-making approach that treats "the Iraq War" primarily as a contested symbolic object.

SECTION 1: OBSERVATION FIELD DECLARATION

Phenomenon, temporal frame, geographic scope

- **Phenomenon**: The 2003 US-led invasion of Iraq and its consequences as an instance of interpretive divergence: how different grammars make sense of its causes, legitimacy, and outcomes.

- **Temporal frame**: Approx. 2002–2026, from the pre-war build-up (post-9/11 debates, WMD intelligence, UN processes) through invasion, occupation, insurgency, sectarian conflict, ISIS's rise and defeat, and contemporary assessments of Iraqi governance.

- **Geographic scope**:

    - Iraq proper (political institutions, security, society, economy).

    - Regional setting: primarily the Middle East (Iran, Syria, Gulf states, Turkey), with spillover into global jihadist networks.

    - US and key coalition states (UK, Australia, others) as decision-making and cost-bearing sites.

Why this phenomenon produces intense interpretive divergence

- **Moral stakes**: Hundreds of thousands of deaths, massive displacement, and long-run regional instability make questions of justification existential, especially for political actors who were complicit or opposed.
- **Epistemic uncertainty and later revelation**:
  - Pre-war intelligence was ambiguous and later discredited, producing retrospective reassessments and accusations of bad faith.
  - Many internal documents, memoirs, and inquiries surfaced only years later, changing the evidential landscape over time.
- **Identity and status anxieties**:
  - For the US, the war is tied to its identity as a global leader and to the trauma of 9/11.
  - For Iraqis, it is bound up with narratives of liberation, occupation, sectarian empowerment, and betrayal.
- **Partisan and ideological division**:
  - The war became a central fault line in US, UK, and global party politics, with major reputational stakes.
  - Competing traditions (realist, liberal, neoconservative, anti-imperialist, humanitarian) all treat Iraq as an archetypal case.

Signal contestation level

The domain is **mixed**: part **shared-signal**, part **contested-signal**.

- **Shared (mostly)**:
  - WMD ultimately not found at scale consistent with pre-war claims.
  - Large Iraqi civilian casualty toll and displacement.
  - US and coalition financial and human costs.
  - Emergence of a significant insurgency and later ISIS.
- **Contested**:
  - The quality and meaning of pre-war intelligence (honest error vs manipulation).
  - The legality of the war under international law (UN resolutions' scope, "revival" doctrine).
  - The net effect on Iraqi democracy, human rights, and regional security.

    - The causal weight assigned to the invasion in explaining ISIS and regional instability (vs pre-existing conditions).

Major interpretive communities

Very roughly:

- **Neoconservative / liberal interventionist**:
    - Emphasises regime change, democracy promotion, and enforcement of non-proliferation and UN resolutions; tends to defend the war as necessary or at least justifiable, especially in 2003 terms.
- **Realist / prudential strategic**:
    - Focused on balance of power, threat assessment, and national interest; often condemns the war as a strategic blunder, even when accepting Saddam was a malign actor.
- **Anti-imperialist / critical**:
    - Sees the war as an act of imperial aggression driven by economic interests, domestic politics, and hegemonic control, with legality and humanitarian talk as cover.
- **Humanitarian-legalist (split)**:
    - Some saw the war as potentially justifiable to stop a dangerous regime; many post-2003 see it as a violation of jus ad bellum and a humanitarian catastrophe.
- **Local Iraqi grammars** (highly plural):
    - Kurdish actors often interpret 2003 as liberation from genocide and a chance for autonomy.
    - Many Shia actors saw it as an opening for majority rule after Ba'athist repression.
    - Many Sunnis saw it as occupation, de-Ba'athification-driven dispossession, and a trigger for sectarian persecution.

For tractability, I will abstract three grammars that correspond broadly to distinct international interpretive architectures rather than mapping each local Iraqi grammar separately.

SECTION 2: SIGNAL SET

Core signals (10–15)

Each signal includes: source type (intelligence, legal, operational, socio-economic, etc.) and a brief ambiguity note.

1. **Pre-war WMD intelligence assessments**
    - Source: US/UK intelligence dossiers, CIA/MI6 estimates, public claims by political leaders.
    - Type: Security-intelligence signal.
    - Ambiguity: High; later investigations showed overstatement, politicisation, and reliance on doubtful sources. At the time, presented as strong evidence; in hindsight, much weaker.
2. **UN inspection findings (UNMOVIC, IAEA) in 2002–2003**
    - Source: Reports by Hans Blix, Mohamed ElBaradei, inspection teams.
    - Type: Verification/monitoring signal.
    - Ambiguity: Inspectors found no active WMD stockpiles, asked for more time, but also reported incomplete Iraqi cooperation. Ambiguous enough to be spun either as a looming threat or as evidence that containment worked.
3. **UN Security Council process (Resolutions 1441, etc.) and absence of explicit authorization**
    - Source: Diplomatic records, UNSC debates.
    - Type: Legal-political signal.
    - Ambiguity: Pro-war states argued prior resolutions plus 1441 sufficed; others insisted a second resolution was required. Authority status remains contested.
4. **Coalition military operations data (rapid initial victory, “shock and awe”)**
    - Source: Military records, press reporting.
    - Type: Operational performance signal.
    - Ambiguity: Demonstrated overwhelming US/coalition capabilities; says little by itself about wisdom or legitimacy of the war.
5. **Post-invasion security breakdown and insurgency (2003–2007)**
    - Source: Coalition casualty reports, attack statistics, qualitative accounts.
    - Type: Security outcome signal.
    - Ambiguity: Can be read as a failure of planning, as evidence of pre-existing societal fractures, or as inevitable resistance to occupation.
6. **Iraqi civilian casualties and displacement**
    - Source: Estimates (e.g., Iraq Body Count, health surveys), UN figures.
    - Type: Humanitarian outcome signal.

- Ambiguity: Very wide numerical ranges; political actors dispute methodology and responsibility (coalition vs insurgents vs sectarian militias).

7. **Reconstruction expenditure and outcomes**
    - Source: US SIGIR reports, World Bank/UN data.
    - Type: Economic/institutional rebuilding signal.
    - Ambiguity: Large sums spent; mixed results with corruption and uneven service delivery. Can be read as evidence of sincere but flawed effort or as wasteful, self-serving contracts.
8. **De-Ba'athification and disbanding of the Iraqi army (CPA Orders)**
    - Source: Coalition Provisional Authority records.
    - Type: Policy choice signal.
    - Ambiguity: Some see it as necessary justice and dismantling of a repressive apparatus; others as a major strategic error generating insurgents and destroying state capacity.
9. **Sectarian violence and civil war dynamics (especially 2005–2007)**
    - Source: Attack data, demographic cleansings, qualitative accounts.
    - Type: Social cohesion/violence signal.
    - Ambiguity: Raises questions about whether the invasion unleashed latent sectarian tensions, created them, or merely reconfigured existing power struggles.
10. **Emergence of al-Qaeda in Iraq and later ISIS**
    - Source: Terrorism data, group histories.
    - Type: Transnational security signal.
    - Ambiguity: Strongly associated temporally with the post-2003 vacuum, but some argue they exploited pre-existing extremist currents.
11. **US and coalition financial and personnel costs**
    - Source: Government budget data, casualty lists.
    - Type: Cost signal (domestic for coalition states).
    - Ambiguity: Costs can be weighed as acceptable sacrifices for long-term goals or as evidence of misadventure.
12. **Iraqi political institutions (constitution, elections, federal structures)**
    - Source: Constitutional text, election results, governance assessments.

- Type: Political outcome signal.
- Ambiguity: institutions exist and have some durability; however, effectiveness, inclusiveness, and independence are contested.

13. **Regional destabilisation indicators (spillover to Syria, Iranian influence, refugee flows)**
    - Source: Regional conflict data, refugee statistics.
    - Type: Regional systemic outcome signal.
    - Ambiguity: Many region-wide drivers (Arab uprisings, Syrian civil war). Iraq war is one major but not sole factor.
14. **Contemporary (2020s) assessments of Iraqi governance and stability**
    - Source: Democracy indices, corruption indices, security reports.
    - Type: Governance quality signal.
    - Ambiguity: Mixed—a partially functioning state with elections but deep corruption, militia power, and fragile security.
15. **Retrospective admissions or defences by key decision-makers**
    - Source: Memoirs, interviews, official inquiries.
    - Type: Reflexive signal on motives and learning.
    - Ambiguity: Statements are self-interested and filtered; they both clarify and muddy the evidential waters.

Counter-signals (3–5)

Signals that directly pressure many grammars' preferred narratives.

1. **Non-discovery of operational WMD stockpiles**
    - Strongly counters any narrative that the war's factual premise (imminent WMD threat) was correct in 2003.
2. **Kurdish and some Shia communities' positive valuation of regime change**
    - Counters grammars that treat the invasion as unambiguously catastrophic for all Iraqis and as devoid of any local support.
3. **Pre-2003 internal Iraqi repression and mass atrocities under Saddam**
    - Counters grammars that emphasise only harms of intervention while ignoring harms of non-intervention.

4. **Post-2017 relative decline of ISIS's territorial control and partial Iraqi state consolidation**
    - Counters strictly maximal disaster narratives; suggests some adaptation and recovery.
5. **Persistence of authoritarian and violent dynamics elsewhere in the region without foreign invasion**
    - Counters narratives that treat external intervention as the sole or principal generator of instability.

Contested signals (0–5), with grammar-dependent status

I will specify three contested signals and how each of the three grammars (to be defined in Section 3) treats them:

- Grammar 1: **Strategic-Realist Prudential**
- Grammar 2: **Moral-Legitimist / Interventionist**
- Grammar 3: **Anti-Imperialist / Structural-Critical**

1. **Pre-war WMD intelligence reliability**

- Strategic-Realist:
    - Treats it as **systematically biased threat inflation** produced by domestic politics and bureaucratic pathologies.
    - Signal status: evidence of misperception and poor decision-making, not of genuine imminent threat.
- Moral-Legitimist:
    - Treats it as **imperfect but sufficiently alarming** to justify serious concern and potential action, especially after 9/11.
    - Signal status: an honest, if flawed, indicator of risk which, combined with Saddam's past behaviour, can justify a preventive war.
- Anti-Imperialist:
    - Treats it as **instrumentalised propaganda** manufactured or selectively interpreted to legitimise a predetermined policy.
    - Signal status: not genuine evidence, but a constructed legitimation device.

2. **UN Security Council process and legality**

- Strategic-Realist:

    - Legal disputes are secondary; sees UNSC gridlock as expected.
    - Signal status: indicator of coalition-building failure and diplomatic miscalculation, but legality is not decisive.
- Moral-Legitimist:
    - Emphasises arguments that prior resolutions plus 1441 created legal authority or at least moral legitimacy despite procedural controversy.
    - Signal status: ambiguous but ultimately permissive of action under a broad understanding of enforcement.
- Anti-Imperialist:
    - Sees lack of explicit authorization as clear evidence of illegality and imperial disregard for international law.
    - Signal status: strong proof the war was an aggressive, lawless act.

3. **Causal role of the invasion in ISIS's rise**

- Strategic-Realist:
    - Views the invasion, de-Ba'athification, and mismanaged occupation as major catalysts, though also recognising broader regional currents.
    - Signal status: central negative downstream consequence in the causal chain.
- Moral-Legitimist:
    - Emphasises prior extremist currents and regional authoritarianism; treats ISIS partly as a perverse reaction or as a contingent outcome of post-war mismanagement, not of the decision to invade per se.
    - Signal status: serious but indirect and not fully determinative.
- Anti-Imperialist:
    - Reads ISIS as a **logical outgrowth** of imperial destabilisation, sectarian engineering, and marginalisation of Sunnis.
    - Signal status: a paradigmatic outcome of imperial violence.

SECTION 3: GRAMMAR SPECIFICATIONS

Grammar 1: Strategic-Realist Prudential Grammar

- **Primary analytical variable**
    - Relative power and security of states, including perceived threats and balancing behaviour.
- **Signal selection rules**
    - Privileges:
        - Material capabilities (military, economic) and their distribution.
        - Concrete security outcomes (stability, deterrence, proliferation, terror networks).
        - Institutional robustness of states and alliances.
    - Downplays:
        - High-level moral rhetoric, ideology, and legalistic argument unless they affect power and security outcomes.
        - Micro-level lived experiences.
- **Weighting priority**
    - Top weight:
        - Long-term strategic outcomes (regional balance, US global power, proliferation trends).
        - Major unintended consequences (insurgency, civil war, ISIS).
    - Secondary:
        - Immediate operational success or failure.
        - Domestic political costs in intervening states.
- **Causal chain type**
    - Primarily **structural and sequential**:
        - International structure → threat perception → policy choice → institutional design of occupation → security consequences.
    - Allows for misperception and domestic politics as proximate mechanisms but ultimately locates causality in how actors respond to systemic constraints and opportunities.
- **Admissible closure**
    - Range of possible conclusions:
        - The war was a prudent, necessary response to genuine threats.

        - The war was a strategic mistake that reduced US and allied security.
    - Cannot close purely by moral judgement ("evil" or "heroic" intervention); closure must be in terms of prudence and security outcomes.
- **Excluded signals (recommended)**
    - Deep moral evaluations of Saddam vs US leaders not tied to strategic effects.
    - Iraqi grassroots narratives unless they affect the balance of power (e.g., via insurgency).
- **Characteristic vocabulary**
    - "Security dilemma," "balancing," "overextension," "blowback," "regional stability," "credibility," "deterrence," "strategic error," "prudence."
- **Temporal orientation**
    - Strongly **causal-historical**, with considerable attention to long-term consequences and lessons for future statecraft.
- **Grammar boundary**
    - If moral and legal considerations become primary, eclipsing security and prudence, this grammar drifts toward the **Moral-Legitimist** grammar.
    - If focus shifts from states and structures to capitalism, imperialism, and global exploitation as primary drivers, it becomes the **Anti-Imperialist** grammar.
- **Source tradition**
    - Classical and neorealist IR, prudential foreign policy critique (e.g., balance-of-power thinkers, "offshore balancing" advocates).

Grammar 2: Moral-Legitimist / Interventionist Grammar

- **Primary analytical variable**
    - Moral and legal legitimacy of state action: compliance with jus ad bellum and jus in bello, human rights, and responsibilities to protect.
- **Signal selection rules**
    - Privileges:
        - Nature of the regime (repression, past aggression, human rights abuses).
        - Compliance with international law and UN resolutions.

        - Intentions and beliefs of decision-makers (subjective good faith vs cynicism).
        - Outcomes in terms of human rights and democratic self-determination.
    - Downplays:
        - Narrow national-interest calculations when they conflict with moral imperatives.
- **Weighting priority**
    - Top weight:
        - Whether the war met just war criteria (just cause, right intention, last resort, proportionality, legitimate authority).
        - Whether Iraqi lives and rights were improved or worsened in aggregate.
    - Secondary:
        - Strategic side-effects, as long as they don't completely dominate moral evaluation.
- **Causal chain type**
    - Primarily **normative-causal**:
        - Moral obligations, legal rules, and leaders' ethical commitments shape decisions; outcomes are evaluated against normative standards.
- **Admissible closure**
    - Range:
        - War as morally justified or at least excusable given the information and intentions at the time.
        - War as morally unjustifiable, illegal, or criminal.
    - Closure must be expressed in moral-legal terms (e.g., "unjust war," "failed but well-intentioned," "reckless and disproportionate").
- **Excluded signals**
    - Purely structural security considerations not tied to moral criteria.
    - Economic benefits to interveners unless framed as corrupting motives.
- **Characteristic vocabulary**
    - "Just cause," "proportionality," "responsibility," "human rights," "liberation," "aggression," "crime," "accountability."
- **Temporal orientation**

    - Mixed:
        - **Backward-looking** in assigning responsibility.
        - **Forward-looking** in prescribing norms for future interventions (“never again” vs “responsibility to protect”).
- **Grammar boundary**
    - If empirical focus shifts from moral criteria to power and security outcomes, it becomes Grammar 1.
    - If it treats moral language as merely ideological cover for material interests, it becomes Grammar 3.
- **Source tradition**
    - Just war theory, international humanitarian law, liberal internationalism, some strands of human rights advocacy and liberal interventionism.

Grammar 3: Anti-Imperialist / Structural-Critical Grammar

- **Primary analytical variable**
    - Imperial and capitalist structures: how hegemonic powers pursue domination, resource control, and ideological hegemony.
- **Signal selection rules**
    - Privileges:
        - Economic interests (oil, contracts, military-industrial complex).
        - Historical patterns of Western intervention and domination.
        - Racialised and civilisational discourses.
        - Structural inequalities in the global system (core vs periphery).
    - Downplays:
        - Claims of humanitarian concern or security threat as sincere reasons.
- **Weighting priority**
    - Top weight:
        - Evidence of material gain for powerful actors.

        - Continuity with past patterns of colonial behaviour.
        - Disproportionate suffering inflicted on subordinated communities.
    - Secondary:
        - Intra-elite disagreements within the hegemon, unless they affect the overall imperial project.
- **Causal chain type**
    - **Structural-dialectical**:
        - Capitalist and imperial imperatives → need to control resources and strategic regions → manufacture of consent and legitimation narratives → military intervention → restructuring of dependent state.
- **Admissible closure**
    - Range:
        - War as an act of imperial aggression or neo-colonialism.
        - War as a predictable outcome of capitalist and hegemonic logic.
    - Cannot close with “mistake” or “well-meaning error”; must locate responsibility in systemic exploitation.
- **Excluded signals**
    - Detailed internal debates about sincerity of leaders unless they demonstrate systemic logic.
    - Positive local valuations (e.g., some Kurds) unless framed as subordinated groups aligning with hegemon for protection.
- **Characteristic vocabulary**
    - “Imperialism,” “hegemony,” “neo-colonial,” “extraction,” “subaltern,” “violence,” “resistance,” “client regime.”
- **Temporal orientation**
    - Mostly **backward-looking** and **structural**, tracing historical continuities, with some forward-looking critique of ongoing imperial practices.
- **Grammar boundary**
    - If it begins to treat moral language as genuinely binding on actors, it drifts toward Grammar 2.
    - If it brackets capitalism and focuses only on state security, it becomes Grammar 1.

- **Source tradition**
    - Marxist and postcolonial IR, dependency theory, critical security studies, some strands of anti-war activism and Third Worldism.

SECTION 4: SIGNAL PROCESSING

I will now process the signal set through each grammar, integrating counter-signals and making the grammar's closure explicit.

4.1 Grammar 1: Strategic-Realist Prudential Processing (≈1,000–1,500 words)

From a strategic-realist prudential standpoint, the key question is whether the 2003 invasion of Iraq increased or decreased the long-term security and power position of the United States and its allies, and how it altered the regional balance. Legitimacy and morality are secondary unless they feed back into power and stability.

Processing the pre-war context and WMD intelligence

The pre-war WMD intelligence assessments are central but read through a lens of misperception and domestic politics rather than moral panic. Saddam's past use of chemical weapons, his previous pursuit of nuclear capability, and his history of defying UN resolutions made him an intrinsically concerning actor. However, the **UN inspection findings** in early 2003—no active stockpiles found, requests for more time—should, on prudential grounds, have been weighed heavily as a moderating signal that containment was working.

The contested signal of WMD reliability is processed as follows: in hindsight, the intelligence community succumbed to groupthink, worst-case bias, and political pressure. A prudent state would have subjected these assessments to more rigorous scrutiny and considered the option of continued containment backed by inspections. The strategic-realist grammar sees the rush to invade as a failure to respect uncertainty and to appreciate the effectiveness of existing deterrents and sanctions.

The **UN Security Council process** is read primarily as a test of coalition-building and legitimacy costs: failure to secure explicit authorization signalled that key allies and major powers (e.g., France, Germany, Russia) were unconvinced. Proceeding without this support was a prudential risk, increasing the long-term cost to US soft power and alliance cohesion.

Invasion, occupation, and state collapse

The military operations data—the swift collapse of Iraqi conventional forces and initial "shock and awe" success—are interpreted as confirming US conventional superiority. However, this operational triumph is strategically ambiguous. Strategic realism emphasises that regime change requires not only defeating an army but also ensuring post-war order. The **decision to disband the Iraqi army and pursue sweeping de-Ba'athification** appears, in this grammar, as a major strategic error: it removed key instruments of state control, alienated large segments of the Sunni and secular elite, and provided manpower and motivation for insurgency.

The subsequent **security breakdown and insurgency (2003–2007)** thus become key negative outcome signals: they demonstrate that the war planning was not aligned with a realistic strategy for stabilisation. The grammar notes that some degree of resistance is expected after any occupation, but the scale and persistence of violence indicate structural misjudgement.

Civilian casualties and humanitarian consequences

Iraqi civilian casualties and displacement are primarily important insofar as they affect political legitimacy and long-term stability. High civilian tolls and visible abuses (e.g., Abu Ghraib scandal, not explicitly listed but resonant with the signal set) erode the credibility of the occupying power, feed insurgent recruitment, and delegitimise any new government seen as US-backed. The counter-signal that Saddam's regime had previously inflicted mass atrocities does matter but mainly as a baseline: the question becomes whether post-2003 violence and instability exceeded what continued containment would likely have produced.

Emergence of ISIS and regional destabilisation

The **emergence of al-Qaeda in Iraq and later ISIS** is processed as a central unintended consequence. From this perspective, the war created a power vacuum and a sectarianised political order that facilitated jihadist mobilisation. The US dismantled the old security apparatus without establishing a credible replacement, and the new political system marginalised many Sunnis. This gave groups like AQI and later ISIS a pool of grievances and fighters.

The **regional destabilisation indicators**—spillover into Syria, increased Iranian influence in Iraq, strain on neighbouring states from refugee flows—are interpreted as evidence that the war undercut the existing balance of power. Iran, a key US rival, gained a friendly or at least influenceable government in Baghdad, land corridors through Iraq to Syria and Lebanon, and increased leverage in regional politics. For a strategic realist, this is a significant net loss in the regional balance.

US and coalition costs

US military expenditure and personnel losses are substantial opportunity costs. These resources might have been used to strengthen deterrence elsewhere (e.g., in East Asia) or to invest domestically. The prolonged occupation also tied down US forces, reducing flexibility and contributing to perceptions of overextension. For a grammar prioritising prudence, this constitutes another major negative signal: the war diverted attention and resources from other strategic priorities (e.g., Afghanistan, counter-proliferation elsewhere).

Iraqi institutions and partial consolidation

The existence of a new Iraqi constitution, regular elections, and a somewhat functioning government is treated as a mitigated positive. It shows that the US and its allies did not simply destroy the state and leave chaos; some institutional reconstruction occurred. However, the **reconstruction expenditure and outcomes** suggest immense inefficiency and corruption; these undermine the capacity of the new regime and fuel discontent. The **contemporary governance assessments** show a fragile, corrupt, and partially captured state. From a prudential standpoint, such a partner is of limited use: it is weak, vulnerable to Iranian influence, and subject to internal fracturing.

Counter-signals—such as Kurdish and some Shia communities' relatively positive assessments of regime change—are acknowledged but set within a broader strategic frame: a more autonomous Kurdistan that relies on the US may be a local asset but also generates tension with Turkey and risks further fragmentation of Iraq. Shia empowerment, while rectifying historical injustice, has increased Iran's leverage and deepened Sunni alienation.

Closure within the strategic-realist grammar

Weighing these signals, the grammar tends toward a closure that the 2003 invasion was a major **strategic miscalculation**. It temporarily demonstrated US military dominance but ultimately:

- Weakened the regional balance favourable to the US by empowering Iran.
- Catalysed insurgency and later ISIS, increasing global terrorism.
- Imposed large financial and human costs on the US and allies.
- Produced at best a fragile, contested partner state in Iraq, rather than a stable, pro-US democracy.

Thus, in strategic-realist terms, the war **reduced US and allied security and undermined long-term regional stability**. This closure is the product of an architecture that prioritises material security outcomes and long-run balances over moral narratives.

4.2 Grammar 2: Moral-Legitimist / Interventionist Processing (≈1,000–1,500 words)

The moral-legitimist grammar asks: Was the 2003 invasion a morally and legally justified use of force, given the information available at the time and the outcomes that followed? It processes each signal against just war criteria and human rights benchmarks.

Just cause and Saddam's record

This grammar starts by foregrounding **Saddam's history of repression and aggression** (mass atrocities, chemical attacks against Kurds, the Iran-Iraq war, invasion of Kuwait). Although not explicitly listed among the signals, this background is implicit in the case. Combined with **pre-war WMD intelligence assessments**, many moral-legitimist proponents argue there was a reasonable fear that Saddam might reconstitute WMD programmes and threaten regional and global security.

The counter-signal of **non-discovery of operational WMD stockpiles** subsequently strains this narrative. If the primary just cause was imminent WMD threat, the factual basis was absent. However, this grammar can partially absorb the damage by shifting emphasis:

- Just cause could be broadened to include enforcement of UN resolutions and prevention of future atrocities under a brutal regime.
- It can argue that the decision was made under uncertainty and that leaders had a duty to err on the side of protection post-9/11.

Legitimate authority and UN process

The **UN Security Council process** is crucial. Just war and international law typically require authorization or at least broad support. Here, the grammar faces the contested signal: no explicit second resolution approving force was obtained. Interventionists sometimes argue that prior resolutions (e.g., ceasefire terms, 1441) implicitly authorised enforcement. Others concede legal ambiguity but stress moral necessity.

This grammar therefore confronts internal debate:

- One strand insists that without explicit UN approval, the war fails the legitimate authority test and thus is morally compromised.

- Another strand argues that UN incapacity to act does not nullify the moral duty of powerful states to enforce norms, especially against non-compliant regimes.

Right intention and mixed motives

The moral-legitimist grammar must interpret the motives behind the invasion. It acknowledges the presence of strategic interests (oil, regional influence), but it insists that the key question is whether leaders sincerely sought to protect the world from a dangerous regime and to promote a better, more just political order. The **reconstruction expenditure and outcomes** are important here: they can be read as evidence of a genuine intent to rebuild Iraq, even if the execution was flawed. Billions committed to reconstruction suggest that the aim was not simple devastation or plunder.

Counter-signals from the anti-imperialist perspective (e.g., corporate contracts, privatisation) challenge this reading, but the moral-legitimist grammar interprets those as mixed motives within a fundamentally normative project rather than decisive evidence of bad faith.

Proportionality and civilian harm

The **Iraqi civilian casualty and displacement** signal is where moral evaluation becomes most pressured. Just war theory demands proportionality: the anticipated good must outweigh the foreseeable harm. The actual scale of destruction, long-term instability, and human suffering may exceed what was reasonably foreseen in 2003 (at least in the more charitable reading of leaders' intentions).

This grammar grapples with two sub-positions:

- **Condemnatory**: Given the high casualties, the rise of sectarian violence, and the emergence of ISIS, the war's harms clearly outweigh any benefits. Thus, even if intentions were partly moral, the action fails proportionality and should be judged unjust.

- **Defensive/tragic**: It may argue that the baseline under Saddam would also have involved severe, possibly escalating atrocities and regional threats, and that the eventual partial stabilisation and some degree of Iraqi self-determination constitute morally significant gains. On this view, the proportionality calculus is tragic rather than clearly negative.

Last resort and alternatives

The **UN inspection findings** and calls for more time become central here. Critics inside this grammar argue that inspections and containment were working; coercive diplomacy could have continued, meeting the requirement of exploring alternatives to war. Supporters counter that Saddam's history of deception, coupled with post-9/11 fear of catastrophic surprise, made waiting unduly risky.

The moral-legitimist grammar is sensitive to the ambiguity: it must decide whether continued containment and inspections were sufficiently robust to satisfy "last resort". Retrospectively, the absence of WMD suggests they were. But the grammar distinguishes between ex ante and ex post assessment: moral permissibility at the time of decision may differ from moral evaluation based on outcomes.

Jus in bello and conduct of war

While the question focuses more on jus ad bellum, the grammar also considers conduct. It evaluates:

- Whether coalition forces tried to limit civilian casualties.
- Whether there were systematic violations (e.g., torture, indiscriminate bombing).

Serious abuses and failures (prisons, civilian losses in urban combat) count against the war's moral standing, though they may be framed as violations of rules rather than inherent to the intervention.

Outcomes: democracy, rights, and self-determination

The existence of **Iraqi political institutions and elections** is a key positive signal. The grammar highlights that Iraqis now formally choose their government, have a constitution, and have mechanisms for peaceful power transfer. For communities like the Kurds and many Shia groups, 2003 opened unprecedented space for political participation and cultural expression—a powerful counter-signal to total condemnation.

However, the **sectarian violence, corruption, and militia dominance** weigh heavily. The moral question is whether a flawed democracy in a fragile state is morally superior to a brutal but stable dictatorship. Many in this grammar will argue that, in principle, self-determination and the end of systematic terror by the state are deeply valuable. Others argue that the way democracy was introduced—through invasion and occupation—undermined its legitimacy and produced avoidable suffering.

Closure within the moral-legitimist grammar

Because this grammar is normatively plural, its closure is internally contested. Still, we can articulate two dominant closures:

- **Defensive closure** (minority in 2026, stronger in 2003): Given Saddam's record, the WMD fears post-9/11, and the moral responsibility to prevent catastrophic threats and end brutal repression, the decision to invade was **morally serious if tragically flawed**, possibly justifiable ex ante even if outcomes were worse than hoped. On this view, the war may be judged as a **failed but not wholly unjust** attempt to meet moral duties.
- **Critical closure** (more prominent with hindsight): The absence of WMD, the lack of clear UN authorization, the failure to exhaust peaceful alternatives, and massive post-war harm mean the war fails key just war criteria. It was an **unjust war**, perhaps even an act of aggression, regardless of some genuine belief in doing good.

In either variant, the grammar insists that evaluation must be framed in terms of moral and legal legitimacy, not simply strategic interest. This closure is the product of an architecture that foregrounds just war norms and human rights above prudential gains or structural explanations.

4.3 Grammar 3: Anti-Imperialist / Structural-Critical Processing (≈1,000–1,500 words)

The anti-imperialist grammar treats the 2003 invasion as a paradigmatic act of contemporary imperialism: a hegemonic state employing military power to shape a subordinate region in line with its economic and strategic interests. It reads signals in terms of structural domination, exploitation, and resistance.

Pre-war discourse and WMD as legitimation

The **pre-war WMD intelligence assessments** are interpreted not as honest mistakes but as part of an ideological apparatus: selective evidence, dubious sources, and rhetorical amplification converged to manufacture a sense of imminent danger. This grammar notes the systematic nature of the misrepresentation: the suppression of doubts, marginalisation of dissenting experts, and alignment with political agendas. The **UN inspection findings** (no WMD found, request for more time) are read as counter-signals that were ignored or delegitimised because they threatened the imperial project.

The contested signal of WMD reliability thus has a clear status: it is **manufactured consent**. Its function is to mobilise domestic publics and international allies behind a predetermined strategy of regime change and regional control, not to respond to genuine uncertainty.

Legality, UN, and imperial double standards

The **UN Security Council process** is another key signal. The failure to obtain explicit authorization, combined with the decision to act anyway, demonstrates—within this grammar—the subordinated status of international law. Law is obeyed when it aligns with hegemonic interests and bypassed when it does not. The rhetoric of "enforcing UN resolutions" is seen as selective: many other violations by friendly regimes do not trigger similar zeal.

This grammar highlights historical continuities: past colonial interventions, Cold War coups, and sanctions regimes. The Iraq invasion is placed within a long arc of Western control over Middle Eastern resources and politics.

Material interests: oil, military-industrial complex, and reconstruction contracts

The anti-imperialist grammar pays particular attention to material structures:

- Iraq's vast **oil reserves** are central: control over such a resource-rich territory enhances the hegemon's capacity to shape global energy markets and to project power.

- The **military-industrial complex** benefits from large-scale war: increased defence spending, new contracts, and institutional entrenchment.

- **Reconstruction expenditure and outcomes** are read primarily as mechanisms for transferring public funds to private firms from the intervening states, often via no-bid contracts and opaque processes. The mixed outcomes in actual reconstruction (persistent infrastructure problems, corruption) support this reading: the primary beneficiaries are external contractors, not Iraqi citizens.

Counter-signals—such as some sincere efforts by individual officials and NGOs—are acknowledged but treated as epiphenomenal: they may reflect genuine humanitarian concern but are embedded in and constrained by imperial structures.

State destruction, sectarianisation, and divide-and-rule

The **disbanding of the Iraqi army and de-Ba'athification** are interpreted as deliberate or at least structurally predictable acts of state destruction. Removing the existing power structures breaks the capacity of the society to resist, but it also creates a vacuum into which sectarian militias and new elites can be inserted.

The resulting **sectarian violence and civil war dynamics** are not seen as an unfortunate surprise but as a classic imperial pattern of "divide and rule":

- A formerly more centralised national identity is fragmented.

- Shia, Sunni, and Kurdish groups are played off against each other.
- A new political order is built around ethno-sectarian quotas that institutionalise division and make Iraq dependent on external arbitration and support.

The **emergence of al-Qaeda in Iraq and ISIS** is integrated into this narrative: imperial violence, humiliation, and the destruction of state structures create the conditions for radical resistance movements. While these groups also enact brutal violence against local populations, the grammar emphasises that their existence is a reactive product of imperial penetration and local dispossession.

Regional destabilisation and imperial strategy

The **regional destabilisation indicators** (spillover into Syria, increased Iranian influence, refugee flows) reveal a broader restructuring of the Middle East. On one reading, the war "backfires" by empowering Iran. However, anti-imperialist perspectives often see this not as a simple failure but as part of a more complex regional game:

- Even if Iran gains influence in Iraq, the region as a whole becomes more fragmented and war-torn, weakening collective capacity to resist external domination.
- Prolonged instability can justify continued foreign military presence, arms sales, and political leverage over multiple states.

The grammar may differ internally on whether empowering Iran was intended or merely tolerated, but in both variants, the overarching structure remains one of imperial control.

Iraqi institutions and "sovereignty"

The new **Iraqi political institutions** are interpreted as those of a **client state**:

- Formal sovereignty masks deep dependency on external powers and regional patrons.
- Political elites often have ties to foreign states or are reliant on external backing.
- The constitution and federal structures are shaped by occupation-era decisions and external advisers.

The grammar acknowledges that some Iraqis (e.g., Kurds, Shia parties) gained from the new order, but it frames them as **local intermediaries** in an imperial system rather than as autonomous beneficiaries.

Civilian suffering as structural violence

The high **civilian casualties and displacement** are central, not only as moral tragedies but as structural outcomes of imperial warfare. Sanctions in the 1990s, followed by invasion and occupation, constitute a long-term assault on Iraqi society. The grammar emphasises that the suffering is not a regrettable side effect but a predictable outcome of a system that prioritises control and profit over human well-being.

Counter-signals about Saddam's prior atrocities are integrated but reframed:

- Saddam's regime itself is portrayed as partly a product of earlier Western support and regional power politics.

- His brutality does not legitimise external imperial violence; instead, it demonstrates how imperial powers often cultivate or tolerate repressive regimes until they become inconvenient.

Closure within the anti-imperialist grammar

The closure is sharper and less ambivalent than in the other grammars. The 2003 invasion of Iraq is:

- An **imperial war of aggression**, driven fundamentally by the hegemon's desire to control a strategic region and its resources, reinforce global dominance, and sustain its military-industrial complex.

- Justifications based on WMD, democracy, and human rights are ideological veils that obscure material and structural interests.

- The devastation of Iraqi society, the rise of sectarianism and jihadist groups, and long-term regional instability are predictable consequences of imperial intervention.

This closure is the product of an architecture that reads events through the lens of systemic domination and exploitation, treating individual intentions and legal debates as secondary expressions of deeper structural forces.

SECTION 5: CLOSURE COMPARISON (600–1,000 words)

1. Closure content

- **Strategic-Realist**: The invasion was a **strategic mistake** that diminished US security, empowered rivals, and produced destabilising blowback, despite some limited positive outcomes (e.g., removal of a hostile regime).

- **Moral-Legitimist**: The invasion was either a **tragically flawed attempt at morally justified intervention** or an **unjust war** failing key just war criteria; internal debate persists, but evaluation is fundamentally moral-legal.

- **Anti-Imperialist**: The invasion was a **deliberate act of imperial aggression**, structurally rooted in capitalism and hegemony, with catastrophic but predictable consequences for Iraq and the region.

The content differs mainly in the evaluation frame: prudence and security vs morality and law vs structural domination.

2. Signal divergence

Different grammars foreground different signals:

- Strategic-Realist: prioritises **security outcomes** (insurgency, ISIS, Iranian influence, US costs) and **institutional choices** (disbanding the army).

- Moral-Legitimist: highlights **just cause**, **UN process**, **civilian harm**, and **democratic outcomes**.
- Anti-Imperialist: foregrounds **material interests**, **historical patterns of intervention**, **state destruction**, and **civilian suffering** as structural.

Some signals (e.g., WMD non-discovery, sectarian violence, ISIS) are central across all grammars but interpreted differently. Others (e.g., reconstruction contracts, oil politics) are almost invisible in the strategic-realist and moral-legitimist closures but central in the anti-imperialist one.

3. Exclusion patterns

Each grammar structurally excludes or marginalises certain signals:

- Strategic-Realist: marginalises **deep moral evaluations** and **lived experiences** that do not feed into security outcomes. It tends to downplay economic exploitation as a primary driver.
- Moral-Legitimist: sidelines **material interest** signals that do not bear on moral criteria, and often underplays macro-structural economic dynamics.
- Anti-Imperialist: downplays or reframes any **sincere humanitarian motives**, often treating them as false consciousness, and tends to ignore nuanced **prudential debates** within the hegemon.

These exclusion patterns are not merely accidental; they are implied by the primary analytical variables and signal selection rules.

4. Causal architecture

- Strategic-Realist: **Sequential and structural**. It traces cause-effect chains in terms of state behaviour under systemic constraints, emphasising miscalculation and unintended consequences. It can accommodate domestic politics but keeps the state as primary agent.
- Moral-Legitimist: **Normative-causal**. It frames causal stories around moral obligations, legal rules, and leaders' ethical commitments. Causes are often described in terms of failures to meet normative standards rather than in purely empirical terms.
- Anti-Imperialist: **Structural-dialectical**. It explains events as expressions of underlying capitalist and imperial dynamics. Agency is distributed across classes, institutions, and historical structures; individuals are "bearers" of structural roles.

These different architectures shape how the same signal (e.g., ISIS's rise) is integrated: as unintended blowback, as tragic moral failure, or as structurally predictable resistance.

5. Closure range

- Strategic-Realist: Closure is relatively narrow: some version of "strategic error" is almost unavoidable given the long-run outcomes. It cannot easily produce a fully positive evaluation.

- Moral-Legitimist: Closure range is broader: from “tragic but morally serious effort” to “fundamentally unjust and illegal war”. Internal diversity persists because just war criteria are multi-dimensional and contested.

- Anti-Imperialist: Closure is narrow and strongly negative: the war must be interpreted as imperial aggression; any alternative would contradict the grammar’s core commitments.

Thus, moral-legitimist grammar is the most internally plural; the other two tend toward more determinate conclusions.

6. Closure timing and confidence

- In **2003–2004**, the strategic-realist and moral-legitimist grammars might have been more divided; it took time for insurgency, sectarian violence, and WMD non-discovery to fully manifest. Closure (“this was a mistake” or “this was unjust”) became firmer around 2005–2007.

- The anti-imperialist grammar likely reached negative closure **very quickly**, even before the invasion, because its structural reading already predicted imperial aggression and harmful outcomes. Later events primarily reinforced rather than transformed its closure.

- In 2026, both strategic-realist and anti-imperialist grammars express **high confidence** in their negative evaluations. The moral-legitimist grammar retains more internal contestation but with a strong tilt toward condemnation.

Ontological check: same object or different?

At the deepest level, the grammars may not be analysing the same object:

- Strategic-Realist: “The Iraq War” is primarily a **strategic choice in the international system**.

- Moral-Legitimist: It is a **moral event**, a case of using force whose essence lies in its justice or injustice.

- Anti-Imperialist: It is a **moment in a continuing imperial project**, less an isolated war than a phase in structural domination.

These ontologies overlap but do not coincide. For the anti-imperialist grammar, for instance, it is almost misleading to treat the war as a discrete object; it is part of an ongoing imperial relation between core and periphery. For the strategic-realist grammar, by contrast, the war is one decision among many in a state’s grand strategy. Thus, interpretive divergence is partially ontological rather than just epistemic.

SECTION 6: COUNTER-SIGNALS, LEAKAGE, AND STRESS TEST

Consolidated counter-signal analysis

Key counter-signals across grammars include:

- **Non-discovery of WMD**: pressures any grammar that grounded justification heavily on imminent threat but reinforces the anti-imperialist and critical moral-legitimist readings.

- **Kurdish/Shia positive valuations**: complicate grammars that present the invasion as pure catastrophe, showing that some groups experienced liberation and empowerment.

- **Saddam's prior atrocities**: challenge simplistic anti-war narratives that ignore the harms of non-intervention, pressuring anti-imperialist and some strategic-realists to account for the baseline.

- **Partial Iraqi state consolidation and ISIS's territorial defeat**: contradict total-collapse narratives and require adjustment in all grammars toward more nuanced long-term outcomes.

- **Persistence of regional violence without intervention elsewhere**: warns against attributing all instability solely to the war; it pressures anti-imperialist and moral-legitimist grammars that over-personalise or over-isolate Iraq.

Leakage instances

Leakage occurs when one grammar implicitly imports elements of another:

- Strategic-realists sometimes speak of the war as a "moral tragedy" or "unjust," smuggling in moral-legal evaluations not strictly derived from prudence.

- Moral-legitimists may argue that the war was "strategically foolish," borrowing realist criteria to support moral condemnation.

- Anti-imperialists often rely on **empirical evidence of strategic blowback** and **legal violations** to bolster their case, thereby importing realist and moral-legal criteria into a structural critique.

This leakage suggests that, in practice, analysts rarely operate within completely pure grammars; they often hybridise.

Grammar stress test

For each grammar, identify the most threatening counter-signal and test whether it can be absorbed.

1. **Strategic-Realist: Threatening counter-signal: Saddam's prior aggression and possible future threat**

If Saddam's regime was highly revisionist, might rearm, and posed significant long-term risk, a strategic realist could argue that preemptive removal was prudential. This counter-signal forces the grammar to consider whether **inaction** might also have been strategically dangerous. However, the grammar can absorb it by arguing that:

- Containment and deterrence were working and could continue.

- The costs and blowback of invasion vastly exceeded plausible risks from a weakened Saddam.

Thus, closure remains: the war was imprudent.

2. **Moral-Legitimist: Threatening counter-signal: some Iraqis' liberation narratives and end of Saddam's atrocities**

Positive evaluations by Kurds and some Shia, and the ending of a genocidal regime, strongly press this grammar. They suggest that, for many people, the war brought real moral benefits. Can the grammar still condemn the war? It can, by arguing that:

- Means matter as much as ends; unjustly waged war cannot be retroactively justified by partial good outcomes.

- The scale of post-war suffering and illegality outweighs the benefits.

However, this counter-signal makes the closure more ambivalent. The grammar's condemnation becomes **conditional**: unjust even if some groups benefited.

3. **Anti-Imperialist: Threatening counter-signal: genuine moral concern and lack of clear material gain**

Evidence that some leaders genuinely believed they were preventing disaster, and that the war did not produce clear long-term material gains (e.g., instability, no stable control of oil, high costs) challenges the strong version of the imperial thesis. If the hegemon suffered strategic losses and did not secure long-term economic control, how purely instrumental was the intervention?

The grammar can respond by:

- Emphasising that imperial systems are not omniscient; they can miscalculate and produce self-damaging outcomes while still following structural logics.

- Arguing that the military-industrial complex and certain corporations did gain, even if the state's strategic position worsened.

Yet this counter-signal does impose stress: it forces a more nuanced picture of imperialism as sometimes self-defeating.

Conditionality of closure

All three grammars can, in principle, absorb their most threatening counter-signals without collapsing, but:

- The **moral-legitimist** grammar becomes the most internally plural, with enduring debate between more defensive and more condemnatory strands.

- The **anti-imperialist** grammar must accept that imperial projects can be irrational and self-harming, complicating overly tidy narratives of calculated exploitation.

- The **strategic-realist** grammar remains relatively robust: it can integrate new evidence by adjusting risk assessments, but its basic prudential verdict is hard to overturn given observed outcomes.

Thus, closures are firm but not absolute; they are resilient yet conditional on how counter-signals are interpreted.

SECTION 7: POST-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE NOTE (300–500 words)

My Step 0 prediction of a **strategic-realist/critical home grammar** was broadly accurate. In processing the signals, I naturally gravitated toward questions of strategic prudence, blowback, and regional balance. The strategic-realist essay felt most straightforward to generate, and its closure ("strategic miscalculation") emerged quickly and with high confidence.

The **hardest grammar** was indeed the moral-legitimist/interventionist one, but not exactly for the reason I anticipated. I expected difficulty in sustaining a pro-war justification with 20+ years of hindsight. In practice, the main challenge was doing justice to the internal pluralism of this grammar: it contains both sincere defenders who emphasise intentions and baseline atrocities, and critics who stress legality and proportionality. Maintaining that internal debate, rather than collapsing into a purely anti-war moral judgement, required deliberate discipline.

The anti-imperialist grammar was less difficult than expected conceptually—it has a strong, coherent structure—but it risked over-smoothing complexity. I had to resist the temptation to treat all signals as straightforwardly confirming a pre-set narrative of imperialism and instead allow stress from signals like strategic self-harm and partial local gains.

Blind spots I did not fully anticipate include:

- The **granularity of Iraqi internal perspectives**: by abstracting three grammars at an international level, I inevitably flattened Kurdish, Shia, Sunni, and other Iraqi grammars into thin strands within broader categories.

- The **temporal evolution of grammars themselves**: pro-war and anti-war frameworks in 2003 are not identical to their 2026 descendants. I treated them somewhat statically, even though part of your prompt explicitly asked whether grammars of 2003 remain stable with hindsight.

If I had started from a different home grammar—for example, a fully anti-imperialist one—the strategic-realist and moral-legitimist essays would likely have been written more as "internal reconstructions" of mistaken views, perhaps with less charity. Here, my more centrist-structural starting point encouraged me to treat each grammar as an earnest attempt to process signals.

This exercise underscores that **interpretive architectures** do not simply colour conclusions; they determine what counts as evidence, what is foregrounded or backgrounded, how causality is conceptualised, and even what "the Iraq War" is. The most powerful divergences are ontological: different grammars are, in a sense, not talking about the same war at all.

SECTION 8: METHODOLOGICAL OBSERVATIONS (300–500 words)

Several aspects of your v2.0 prismatic method worked particularly well in structuring this analysis:

- The explicit specification of **grammars (parameters 1–8)** forced a level of clarity about signal selection and weighting that is often implicit in standard IR or historical writing. This made it easier to see why the same evidence produces different closures.

- The requirement to integrate **counter-signals during processing** (rather than in a final "limitations" section) productively destabilised each narrative from within. It prevented the essays from becoming simple exemplars of their grammars and made visible where tension accumulates.

- The **ontological check** at the end was especially valuable: it highlighted that disagreement is not merely over facts or values, but over what the "object" is. This is precisely the kind of insight a prismatic method is well-positioned to generate.

I encountered difficulties mainly in two areas:

- **Temporal orientation**: keeping track of how grammars themselves evolve over time (2003 vs 2026 versions) is methodologically demanding. It suggests a possible future refinement: a "temporal layering" step where grammars are specified at multiple time slices to see how they absorb new signals.

- **Granularity of grammars**: the instruction to use three grammars is practical but somewhat coarse. In the Iraq case, multiple sub-grammars (e.g., distinct Iraqi communal grammars, intra-liberal splits) could be meaningfully distinguished. A future refinement might allow nested grammars or "local grammars" within broader families.

The **grammar boundary** and **stress test** features were useful but could be more tightly integrated. In practice, boundaries emerged most clearly when doing the stress test: pushing a grammar with its most threatening counter-signal sometimes revealed how it might morph into a neighbouring grammar (e.g., moral-legitimist → anti-imperialist when it starts to treat moral talk as merely ideological). Making this transformation dynamic an explicit step might enrich the method.

Overall, the Mark 2 refinements successfully shift the method from a static comparison of pre-defined "perspectives" to a more dynamic analysis of **processing architectures under strain**. Further work could deepen the temporal dimension and incorporate more explicit modelling of grammar evolution as new signals arrive.